trying to tell me something I could not understand. I remained seated and was about to return to the drawing when the man spoke.

'May I know what you are doing?'

I was a bit irritated at being disturbed by a stranger, and my impulse was to retort, 'Who are you?'

Better sense prevailed and I said, 'I am designing an explosive bolt.'

The next question: 'How much time would you take to make the bolt? Now I was irked. I said, 'Who are you?'

By now Kalam was furiously gesticulating, and I realised this man was someone big. He smiled and said, 'They call me Vikram.'

Even then I didn't realise that the smiling intruder was Vikram Sarabhai. After he left, Kalam came running.

'Do you know who he is?' he said. 'He is Vikram Sarabhai, the space programme chairman. Why didn't you get up?'

I said I did not know who he was, plus it was difficult to spring up with the drawing board and set squares around me. That was the truth. Sarabhai became the person I admired most with his uncanny ability to foster the spirit of commitment in his men, encourage healthy competition, and give India a direction to become a space super power.

Later, after I realised the stature of Sarabhai, I thought I should have stood up and saluted him even if I was hanging upside down. In our internal parlance, my grade meant just that—hanging upside down. I was Scientist B (SB); and 'B' stood for bat. The other grades—in the ascending order of seniority were SC, SD, SE, SF, SG, then a plain 'G' before 'H'. Above all these was the chairman post.

Each alphabet was assigned—unofficially of course—the name of an animal. 'C' stood for cat, meaning someone who stealthily moves around and often has nine lives, 'D' signified dog for the barks and sometimes the loyalty. Dogs graduated to become elephants that walk with a thud before turning into cunning foxes. Then, we joked, the scientists became goats of the sacrificial kind. The plain 'G' stood for 'absolute goat'. If the goats survive long enough, they become horses that walk majestically and gallop.